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For men and elders

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In the 1934–8 period, and still in 1955, the Nyakyusa-Ngonde thought well of themselves. They insisted on their skill as cattle-owners, their diligence and skill in cultivation, their prowess as warriors in the defeat of the Ngoni, the fame of their lineages of chiefs, their democratic institutions as contrasted with the subservience of the Bemba and other peoples; the 'good company' enjoyed in their villages; the order and cleanliness of their homesteads and persons, as compared with neighbouring Kinga, Safwa, Nyiha. All their neighbours, said the Nyakyusa, were learning their language. They often spoke disparagingly of Swahili, particularly of Swahili women, as dirty and immoral; they were equally disparaging about the manner of life of some Europeans on the Lupa gold-fields, and about certain South Africans who had trekked north to Kenya. The Henga presented a challenge to Ngonde because Kondowe was in Tumbuka country, and the Henga section of the Tumbuka had accepted education early, some also travelling far as labour migrants. Ngonde women had copied from Henga women in beginning to hoe. The Kyungu's most sophisticated wife was a Henga, and so was Nyasuru (her mother's brother) who was leader of the African National Church (M. Wilson 1959:190–7). But the Henga had taken refuge in the Kyungu's kingdom, and had been regarded as disloyal subjects (Fotheringham 1891:47, 112–5), so relationships were ambivalent. Attitudes toward Sangu who had been slavers were also inconsistent, but they were regarded with some respect. The Ngoni were spoken of as equals who, without question, could be joking partners of Nyakyusa at labour centres (M. Wilson 1957b). English was the acceptable second language both because of its practical use when men travelled for work, and because it obviated invidious comparisons with other African languages. Despite criticisms, whites were recognized as knowledgeable and skilled, people from whom men could learn and profit. Their material possessions outshone all others. We treasured the remark of a small boy, heir

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to a chiefdom and the epitomy of elegance in a patterned cloth, who said to us two exceedingly shabby anthropologists: 'I think you are the best-dressed people I have ever seen.'

The example of outsiders was repeatedly spoken of as something that influenced family relationships: 'You do not know what being a woman is like, you eat with your husband.' 'We saw Europeans eat with their children and also Swahili, and it seemed as if we hated our children.' 'Henga women brought the custom that women should hoe.' 'A Safwa man made a will. That was a good thing to do.' By and large Nyakyusa and Ngonde people accepted change as something good; in this they contrasted sharply with the conservative section of Xhosa-speakers among whom I had worked previously (Hunter 1936). But in certain situations the occurrence of change was scarcely admitted, even by Nyakyusa and Ngonde. In marriage contracts, when cash was substituted for labour service or for cattle, the substitution was often not mentioned in later discussion: what was important was 'hoeing' for in-laws and handing over a specified number of 'cattle'.

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